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UNDERSTANDING NEPAL'S GOVERNMENT SYSTEM

A Field Guide for the Planetary Health Transect

1. Why Understanding the Government Matters on a Transect

When you step off the bus in Bharatpur and walk into the Bharatpur Metropolitan City Hall, or when you sit with a ward chairperson in Lo Manthang at 3,800 metres above sea level, you are witnessing the same system — Nepal's federal structure — working in dramatically different contexts. Understanding this system is your key to interpreting everything else on the transect: why a certain road exists, who decides where a school goes, and why a given community has access to electricity while the next valley does not.



Key

The same Constitution of Nepal 2015 governs the ward office in Chitwan's flat terai and the remote rural municipality of Upper Mustang. But the resources, capacity, and context differ enormously — and that gap is the story.

Nepal underwent one of the most ambitious government transformations in recent South Asian history when it shifted from a centuries-old centralised monarchy to a three-tier federal democratic republic, all sealed by the 2015 Constitution. For the first time in Nepal's history, citizens at the most local level — the ward — could directly elect their own leaders with constitutional authority.

2. Nepal at a Glance

Official Name	Federal Democratic Republic of Nepal
Capital	Kathmandu (also the largest city)
Population	~30.3 million (National Census 2021)
Total Area	147,181 km ² — smaller than Germany, bigger than Bangladesh
Geographic Zones	Terai (Plains) Hills (Pahad) High Himalaya — all within ~200 km
Official Language	Nepali (written in Devanagari script); 123 languages spoken nationally
Constitution	Promulgated 20 September 2015 — marking shift to federal republic
Form of Government	Federal Democratic Republic with three tiers of government
First Federal Election	November–December 2017; subsequent election held in 2022
Head of State	President (ceremonial) — elected by Federal Parliament
Head of Government	Prime Minister — must command majority in House of Representatives
Districts	77 districts (administrative units; not a governance level under 2015 constitution)
Local Governments	753 total: 6 metros, 11 sub-metros, 276 municipalities, 460 rural municipalities

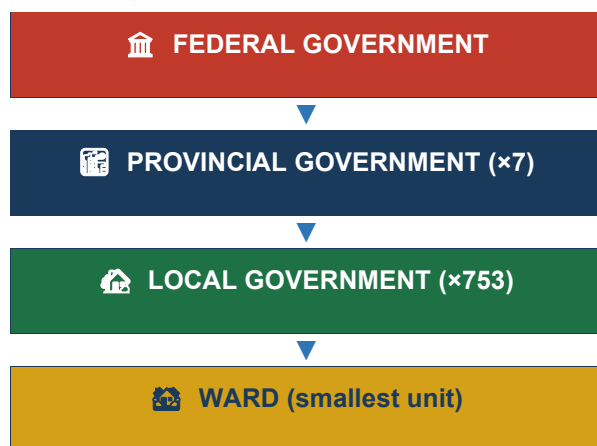
3. The Three-Tier Federal Structure

Nepal's 2015 Constitution (Article 56) is clear: 'The main structure of the Federal Democratic Republic of Nepal shall be of three levels, namely the Federal, Provincial and the Local.' Each level has its own elected legislature, executive, and judicial functions. This is not a hierarchy where upper levels micromanage lower ones — each tier has constitutionally protected powers.

Constitution Quote

Article 56, Constitution of Nepal 2015: 'The Federal, Provincial and Local levels shall exercise the power of the State of Nepal under this Constitution and law.'

3.1 The Governance Pyramid



Note: 'Wards' (the smallest unit) sit beneath Local Government and are the building blocks of municipalities and rural municipalities.

4. Tier 1 — Federal Government

♀ Where
you'll see it

Army checkpoints on the Jomsom–Mustang highway; Customs office at Jomsom Airport; National Park entry gates; CDO office in district headquarters; national highway markers.

Commented [1]: Full Form

5. Tier 2 — Provincial Government

♀ Where
you'll see it

Gandaki Province Government Building in Pokhara (Chief Minister's office); provincial police in Beni; provincial road projects along the Kali Gandaki corridor; Dhaulagiri Hospital (provincial).

5.1 The Seven Provinces — At a Glance

★ marks provinces on our transect route (Chitwan → Upper Mustang)

No.	Province	Capital	Area (km ²)	Pop. (2021)	Districts
1	Koshi	Biratnagar	25,905	4,972,021	14
2	Madhesh	Janakpur	9,661	6,126,288	8
3	Bagmati ★	Hetauda	20,300	6,084,042	13
4	Gandaki ★	Pokhara	21,504	2,413,907	11
5	Lumbini	Deukhuri	22,288	4,891,025	12
6	Karnali	Birendranagar	27,984	1,694,889	10
7	Sudurpashchim	Dhangadhi	19,539	2,711,270	9

Source: National Census 2021, Government of Nepal. Population figures are official census data.

5.2 Spotlight — Gandaki Province (Transect Province)

Mustang district — where you will spend a significant part of the transect — falls under Gandaki Province. Gandaki was previously known as Province No. 4 and is named after the Gandaki River, the major waterway draining the Annapurna and Dhaulagiri ranges.

Capital Pokhara	Districts 11	Local Units 85	Area 21,504 km ²
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Key districts on your route within Gandaki: Chitwan (partially in Bagmati) → Tanahun → Kaski (Pokhara) → Myagdi → Mustang.

6. Tier 3 — Local Government

 Where you'll see it

Bharatpur Metropolitan Hall in Chitwan; Beni Municipality office; Thasang Rural Municipality in Mustang; Ward Office in Lo Manthang. This is where the government touches citizens daily.

Commented [2]: It will be good to mention the list of Metropolitan, Municipality and Rural Municipality the transect is crossing

6.1 The Ward — Government at Doorstep

Every local government is subdivided into wards. There are approximately 6,743 wards in Nepal. Each ward has:

- 1 Ward Chairperson (directly elected)
- 4 Ward Members (directly elected; at least 2 must be women; 1 from Dalit community)
- 1 Women's Committee Member (elected by ward-level committee)

The Ward is where birth registrations happen, where citizenship applications begin, where small construction permits are issued, and where local disputes are first mediated. In Lo Manthang (Upper Mustang), the ward office may operate from a single room, but it carries the same constitutional authority as a ward in central Kathmandu.

 Human Impact

Before 2015, a person in Upper Mustang needed to travel to Kathmandu for many government services. Today, their ward office handles birth registration, death certificates, migration records, and local permits. The ward chairperson is their elected neighbour.

6.2 Local Government Powers (22 Exclusive)

Schedule 8 of the Constitution gives local governments 22 exclusive functions, including:

- Primary and secondary education management
- Basic health services and sanitation
- Local roads, bridges, and rural market management
- Drinking water and local irrigation
- Birth, death, migration, and natural calamity records
- Agricultural extension and livestock services
- Local tax collection (property, business, advertisement)
- Local environmental protection
- Mediation and settlement of local disputes (judicial quasi-function)

14. Key Sources & Further Reading

The following authentic sources were used in preparing this guide and are recommended for deeper study:

- Constitution of Nepal, 2015 (2072 BS) — Official text: www.constituteproject.org/constitution/Nepal_2015
- Local Government Operation Act, 2074 (2017) — Governs local government functions
- National Natural Resources and Fiscal Commission — www.nnrfc.gov.np
- Nepal Government National Portal — www.nepal.gov.np
- Federal Parliament of Nepal — www.parliament.gov.np
- World Bank: 'Supporting Nepal's Historic Transition to Federalism' (2020)
- National Census of Nepal 2021 — Central Bureau of Statistics, Government of Nepal
- Annapurna Conservation Area Project (ACAP) — www.ntnc.org.np
- Gandaki Province Government — www.gandakiprovince.gov.np
- Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal — www.caanepal.gov.np (Jomsom Airport info)